



THE LONG GRACE

SEVEN TABLES

LANDS · LIVES · LEAVINGS

A COMPANION TO THE CORE BOOK · A ROLEPLAYING GAME OF EATEN GODS

EVERY LAND IS CERTAIN THAT THE CURE IS NEXT DOOR.
EVERY LAND IS CERTAIN THAT THE MONSTER IS
NOT AT ITS OWN TABLE.

[RIM ROAD SAYING]

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▼ BEFORE THE SECOND COURSE

Six peoples ate. One refused. Every one of them is still chewing.

– RIM ROAD SAYING

FROM A LETTER FOUND IN THE SACHEL OF A CUTWRIGHTS' COLLEGE SURVEYOR, SEALED BUT NEVER SENT.

Sister, you asked me what the lands are like, and I keep failing to tell you, because the honest answer is that they are like people. Not like nations. Not like maps. Like people at a long table after a meal that went on too long: one has fallen asleep with her eyes open, one is still eating, one is weeping into the soup, one keeps promising to leave and cannot stand, one is giving birth under the table, one has died and will not stop

talking, and one stands by the door with his coat on, refusing everything, insufferable, starving, right.

I have spent eleven years writing down their names. Every name I write I have come to think of as a kind of plate: something with a portion on it. Something that will be eaten.

I am enclosing the ledger. Do not open it at the table.

The Long Grace core book gave you the Table: its history, its seven lands, its rules, its market and its monsters. This book is the second course. It is about **the people**, and about **what is left of the gods when someone takes a knife to them**.

▼ WHAT THIS BOOK CONTAINS

Part One: The Seven Tables returns to each land and goes down to street level. Every land opens with a deep-dive into how it actually works day to day: its districts and villages, roads and wages, courts and punishments, shrines and hymns, the voices of its ordinary people, and a map of who holds power over whom. Then comes the heart of the book: **every named character of every land**, written in full. Each dossier gives a complete stat block, a quote in the character's own voice, who they are and how they smell and sound, their story, how they function inside their land's institutions, **everything they carry**, their wants and fears and secrets, their ties to the rest of the cast, how to use them in play, and what other people say about them behind their backs. Each land closes with its newer

faces, a web of its relationships, and a table for deciding who comes knocking.

Part Two: Leavings is a catalogue of relics. On the Table, a god is not only a power in the blood; it is meat, bone, breath, silence, salt and gristle, and people have been cutting pieces off it for six hundred and forty-one years. The Leavings chapters describe what can be taken from the gods, from the godsign-touched, from the horrors and places of each land, and from the Host's tables: how to have heard of it, how to carve it, how long it keeps, how badly it taints, what it does, and what it is worth. A short rules chapter, *The Carving Knife*, explains how harvesting works.

USING THE DOSSIERS

The dossiers are written to be used at the table, not admired on the shelf. Every one of them answers four questions a Carver needs mid-session:

- ◇ **What do they look, sound and smell like?** Read the first paragraph of *Who They Are* aloud.
- ◇ **What do they want from the Guests?** See *In Play*.
- ◇ **What happens if they fight?** The stat block uses the core-book rules exactly: 2d10 + Attribute + Skill, Teeth for Partaking,

Flesh, Guard, Armor, Dread.

- ◇ **What happens if nobody intervenes?** Every dossier ends its *In Play* section with the character's fate if the Guests do nothing. These are the clocks of the Table. Use them.

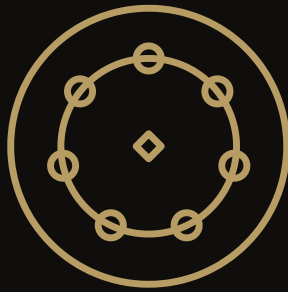
Not every secret printed here is true in your campaign. Where the book offers options, choose one, and let the others become rumours.

▼ A REMINDER ABOUT CONTENT

This is a book about people being eaten by their gods and each other, in detail. Everything in the core book's content warning applies here, and more intimately, because these are faces the Guests will come to know. Keep using Lines, Veils and the Grace. Suicide and self-harm in these pages are tragedies, written from the side of the people left behind; nothing here is instruction. Sexual taboo, cursed bloodlines and desecration of the dead remain implied and adult. Children appear in these pages, as they appear on the Table; their suffering is shown through the adults who fail them, and never lingered on.

READING A DOSSIER STAT BLOCK

- ◇ **Land & Cut:** the character's land, bloodline strength (0–5), Regrowth (0–12) and current Hunger (0–10).
- ◇ **Calling & Standing:** the nearest core-book Calling and their rank in it (1–5), so you can see what their institution will do for them.
- ◇ **Attributes / Skills:** used exactly as for Guests. Threat-rated minor figures appear as one-line quick stats.
- ◇ **Flesh · Guard · Armor · Fray:** physical durability, the number to hit them, damage reduction, and how near they are to Breaking.
- ◇ **Gifts / Wants:** the god's powers in them and the compulsions that come with those powers.
- ◇ **Carries:** a summary; *What They Carry* gives the details, including items from the Rim Market and Leavings.
- ◇ **Dread:** the Dread rating of encountering them at their worst.



PART ONE

THE SEVEN TABLES

Every land at street level, and every face at its table.



CHAPTER 1
THE FAST

The Country Kept for a Guest

Carry your own. Count your chairs. Close the gate, and then go through it again.

– WHAT A WANTING MOTHER SAYS AT THE DOOR EACH MORNING, IN PLACE OF
GOODBYE

A day of Meagre Toft, Measure-Bearer, aged fifteen, of Pantry Close in Wanting. Set down by the Hostwatch clerk who walked with her, for the ledger of ordinary days the Warden of the Map keeps “so that someone will remember what the Fast was like before.”

She wakes in the dark because the cold wakes her. There is frost on the inside of the shutter, and she puts her palm flat on it before she does anything else, because frost inside means the god was nowhere near the house in the night. Then she puts her palm flat on the bricked place in the wall where her great-grandmother’s grandmother had a hearth. Cold. Good. She says the Five Rules under her breath into the blanket, all five, quickly, the way you check your pockets, and gets up.

Her mother is already standing against the wall, dressed in everything she owns. Her little brother is asleep on the pallet with his head to the door. Nobody says good morning. Her mother says, “Carry your own,” and Meagre says, “I carry my own,” and takes the ration-cloth off the shelf, and the water flask, and the wax tin, and goes out, and closes the door behind her from the outside, and then opens it and goes back in and closes it again from the inside and goes out again. That is how her family does it. Other families have other ways. All of them are about the door.

Pantry Close is grey at that hour and full of people standing still. The Ration Line has formed in the night, as it does every night, four abreast and back along the Close and round the corner into Hillward, a long dark bundle of wool and breath. Nobody talks in the Line. It costs too much. You can hear the whole town breathing, and the breath smells of pear-drops, which is the smell of bodies eating their own fat because there is nothing else, and you can hear the Pantry clock, which has no face, only a bell, and you can hear coughing. Meagre does not join the Line. She goes round the side to the Bearers’ door, which is the only door in Wanting that opens inward, and which is held by a spearman who looks at her face and her hands and the Bearer’s cord at her wrist, and says, “Declined,” and she says, “Declined,” and he lets her in.

Inside the Pantry it is warmer than anywhere else in the town, and it is not warm. It smells of sacking and mouse and dust, and, very faintly, of oats, and to Meagre that is the smell of being alive. Mother Stint Avery is at the great brass scales in the weighing-hall, as she is every morning, with her sleeves

rolled to the elbow and her forearms white with oat-dust. She does not look up. She is weighing out the Bearers’ measures for the outlying hamlets into cloth bundles, one bundle per name, and as she ties each one she says the name aloud, once, flatly, and a clerk writes it, and another clerk checks it against the list, and the bundle goes into a Bearer’s basket. Meagre’s basket is for Thinwick and Sallow Hatch and the four farms along the Brindle road. Thirty-one names. She counts the bundles. Thirty-one. She counts them again. She is not supposed to look at the list. She has never looked at the list. She knows there were thirty-three names last week.

She walks out of Wanting with the basket on her back as the sky goes pale. The frost is thick on the fields east of the town, which is good. The frost is thin on the fields west, which is not. Out past the Frostline markers, which are white-painted stakes the Hostwatch move every week, the grass goes from white to grey to green, and you can see where the warm ground begins, a soft edge like the line a wet cloth leaves on a table. She keeps east of it. Everyone does. The road is empty and very quiet and the basket is heavy, and the bundles in it smell of oats and lard, and her stomach turns over once, hard, like something in a sack.

At Thinwick a woman is waiting at the hamlet stone with her hands folded. Meagre gives her four bundles. The woman says, “No, thank you,” three times, and Meagre offers a fourth time, and the woman takes them, and does not look into Meagre’s basket, and does not ask about the two names that are not in it. At the second farm on the Brindle road nobody comes out. Meagre stands at the gate and calls the name, as she is supposed to, three times. Then she puts the bundle on the gatepost, as she is supposed to, and walks on, and does not look back, because a bundle left on a gatepost is not offered, it is only set down, and whoever takes it is carrying their own.

The smell finds her on the way home, at about the time of the afternoon when the light in the Fast stops changing. Bread. It comes from the west, faint, over the warm ground, and her mouth floods so fast she chokes. She turns her face into the wind. There is no wind. She turns her face east, then, toward the Rim, and walks with her mouth open and her tongue flat, breathing as little as she can, and spits every forty steps, and counts them, and does not think about bread, and thinks about bread.

In the Cold Yards at dusk her mother is crouched over a fire no bigger than a hand, warming the evening's measure in a clay pot. The fire is stamped out the instant the pot steams. They eat standing, facing the yard wall, each from their own hand, half an oatcake and a thumb of lard and a mouthful of pease that tastes of the pot. Her brother closes his eyes while he chews, and her mother hits him, not hard, on the back of the head. He opens them. Nobody says anything. Somewhere further down the Yards a man is weeping as he eats, quietly and steadily, and nobody looks at him either.

At night Pantry Close is lit by one lamp at the iron door, under which the Keeper reads the next day's list. Meagre goes, as everyone goes. Mother Stint Avery reads the names without any expression at all, for forty minutes, in a voice that does

not change on any name. Meagre hears her own. She hears her mother's. She hears her brother's. She does not hear the name of the man who was weeping in the Cold Yards, and when she looks for him in the crowd he is already walking away, slowly, toward the Lean End, with his hands at his sides.

She goes home. She closes the door from the outside, and opens it, and closes it from the inside. She puts her palm on the bricked hearth. Cold. She lies down with her head to the door. Somewhere out on the warm ground, a long way west, there is a single light, gold, the size of a pinprick, where a table has been laid in an empty house for someone, and she watches it through the crack in the shutter until she falls asleep, and does not say thank you to it, and wants to.

▼ GROUND LEVEL

The core book tells you why the Fast is what it is. This chapter tells you what it is like to live there: to queue, to carry, to be counted, to walk the roads, to be poor in a country where nobody is rich, and to be judged in a country with no courts. The Fast is not a land of dramatic institutions. It is a land of small, constant, exhausting procedures, of doors closed twice and names said once, of palms laid flat on cold brick, and the horror of it is mostly in the procedures, because each one is a little fence put up around a terrible want, and the fences are getting old.

Remember, running it, three things about the Unfed at ground level. They are always cold, because a body without fat cannot hold heat and there are no fires indoors. They are always tired, because a Pantry measure keeps an adult upright and no more. And they are always, every minute of every day, being offered something, by a god who has never once raised its voice. The Unfed have built a whole civilisation out of saying no to that offer, and they are very proud of it, and they are very, very hungry.

WANTING: THE TOWN WITH NO KITCHENS

Wanting sits on a long, low, limestone ridge on the eastern margin of the Fast, half a day's walk from Brindle Cross and the Rim Road. It was built in 188 A.G., when the last Unfed abandoned the heartland, and it was built to a single idea: that nothing in it should look like an invitation. The streets run straight and the houses are all the same: long, low, grey, slate-roofed, chimneyless, with narrow windows and iron-strapped doors hung to open outward. There are no signs, no painted shutters, no window-boxes, no benches. There is nowhere to sit down in the whole of Wanting except the floor of your own house. Visitors from the Rim find it the most depressing town on the Table, and say so, and are not invited back, which is a joke the Unfed enjoy in silence.

About nine thousand people live in Wanting, and about four thousand more in the hamlets and steadings scattered in a ring around it, none more than a day's walk out, all on the cold side of the Frostline. Everything in the Fast that is not the god's lives within that ring. The town has no walls. It has the Frostline, a ring of white-painted stakes the Hostwatch move every week to mark where the warm ground ends; inside it is the Unfed's country, and outside it is Orrum's.

The town is divided into quarters that the Unfed do not call quarters, since a quarter is a portion. They call them *stands*, after the stretches of the trench at Hallowboard where the families of the hill once stood, and each stand has its own families, its own habits about doors, its own way of saying the Decline. A child of Hillward can be told from a child of the Spit by how they close a gate.

PANTRY CLOSE

The heart of Wanting is not a square, because a square is a place to gather and gathering is a kind of feast. It is a wide, bare, cobbled ring around the Pantry tower, kept swept and empty, with the town's six main streets running into it like spokes. The Ration Line forms here every night and moves at dawn, four abreast, round the tower and in at the window on the north side, where each household's chit is taken and its measure handed out through an iron hatch. At dusk the Close fills again for the reading of the list. The rest of the day it is the emptiest place in Wanting.

It smells of cold stone, wool, and the pear-drop breath of the Line. It sounds like coughing, and the bell of the Pantry clock, which strikes the hours and, on list nights, a single extra stroke after the last name. Pantry clerks, Measure-Bearers and Listers live in the narrow houses around the Close, and are envied for it, because to live within sight of the iron door is to feel, a little, that you will not be forgotten.

Custom: nobody crosses the Close diagonally. You walk around it, as you walk around the bare space in the middle of your own house where a table would be. Children who cut across are made to walk the full ring three times. *Danger:* the Close is where the omitted learn that they are omitted, and every few weeks one of them does not take it quietly. A man left off the list in 639 stood at the iron door and beat on it with both fists until the bones in his hands broke, and the spearmen let him, because to stop him would have been to touch him, and to touch him would have been a kindness.

HESITATE BRUNE, NIGHT LISTER Threat 2 · Flesh 10 · Guard 11 · Attack +2 (fist 1) · Armor 0 · Dread 0. A gaunt young clerk who copies the list each evening before it is read, and has started, very lightly, in pencil, to copy the names that are struck out. He keeps them in his shoe.

HILLWARD

The oldest stand, on the crown of the ridge, where the families who claim the clearest descent from Hallowboard live in the longest, coldest, barest houses in town. Hillward houses are older than the rest and plainer, if that is possible, and their doors are the heaviest: some are two inches of oak strapped with four bands of iron, and take two people to open. The Abstinence's elders live here, and Wont Bellamy, and the Wend family. Elder Forbear Wend is carried down Hillward Row to the Pantry every morning in his ash chair, and the street stands back against the walls as he goes by.

Hillward smells of nothing at all, which is its boast. It is the quietest stand in Wanting, and the most watched, because its people are watched by everyone else for any sign of softness: a curtain, a cushion, a cheek that has filled out. The Hillward families trade in nothing. They hold standing, which in the Fast is the only property: the right to stand at a particular place in the trench at Hallowboard on Tablenight, handed down from the ones who stood.

Custom: Hillward households keep a *stand-stone*, a chip of chalk from their ancestors' stretch of the trench, set into the floor by the door, and every member of the family puts a bare foot on it before going out. *Danger:* reputation. A Hillward family whose member is seen enjoying a meal can lose its stand, and with it everything, inside a season.

OLD PINCH CORVE, HILLWARD DOORWARDEN Threat 3 · Flesh 9 · Guard 10 · Attack none · Armor 0 · Dread 0. Ninety-one, blind, sits at the top of Hillward Row from dawn to dusk and can name every person who passes by the sound of their breathing; he reports any breath that smells of anything but hunger.

THE COLD YARDS

Six walled squares of beaten earth on the south and west edges of town, where all the cooking in Wanting is done. The walls are high, to keep the smell of food from reaching the streets, and the yards are open to the sky. In each yard there are dozens of fire-pits, shallow scrapes in the earth lined with flint, and at the two hours of the day when the yards are open (an hour after dawn and an hour before dusk) each pit has a household crouched at it, warming the day's measure in a clay pot over a fire made of a single handful of Rim kindling. The fire is stamped out the moment the pot steams. No fire in Wanting burns longer than it takes to warm a mouthful.

The Yards are the closest thing in Wanting to a public life, and they are dreadful. Two hundred hungry people crouched in a walled square, each over a little pot, each with their back to the others, each careful not to look, each careful not to smell, and the air thick with the smell of warm oats and lard, which to an Unfed nose is very nearly unbearable. It sounds like spoons on clay and the hiss of stamped-out fires, and every evening, somewhere, someone weeping while they eat.

Custom: you eat facing the wall. You eat standing. You do not close your eyes. Children are taught by being struck lightly on the back of the head. *Danger:* the Yards are where hoarding and mouth-theft happen, and where the Abstinent's Yard-wardens watch for them. A Yard-warden's word can cut a family's measure for a month. Worse: on still evenings the smell from the Yards travels west, and twice in living memory a table has been found laid in the West Yard at dawn, inside the walls, with every fire-pit lit.

YARD-WARDEN FALLOW STEEN Threat 2 · Flesh 11 · Guard 12 · Attack +4 (staff 3) · Armor 1 · Dread 0. A broad, sour woman who walks the West Yard with a staff and a slate, and marks the names of anyone she sees chewing with their eyes shut. She is very good at it because she does it herself, every night, alone.

THE SPIT

A low, muddy, crowded stand on the east side of the ridge, down by the Brindle road, where the Crumb-Runners live. It has the only stables in Wanting, long sheds of rough timber for the oxen and handcarts, and the only buildings with locks on the inside: Runners keep their stock in their houses for a night before the Pantry takes it, and they have learned to bar their doors. The Spit is called the Spit because that is what the rest of Wanting does when a Runner walks by, and it was called that so long ago that the Runners call it that too, without irony, the way a scarred man calls himself Scar.

It smells of ox, wet straw, axle-grease, sacking, and food. That last is the thing. Even after the cargo has gone up to the Pantry, the houses of the Spit smell of oats and cheese and salt fish, faintly, all the time, and to other Unfed the smell is both an outrage and a pull, so that children of other stands dare one another to walk the length of Spit Lane breathing through the nose. The Runners are the least pious, least thin and best informed people in the Fast. They are spat on in the street. They wipe it off and go on.

Custom: a Runner who comes home from a run stands in Spit Lane and empties every pocket onto the ground, and turns them out, so that the street can see they have brought back nothing for themselves. *Danger:* poachers. Kale Dragoman's agents drink at the Brimming Cup on the Rim side of Brindle Cross and buy information from Runners in debt, and more than one Unfed taken across the Rim was named to the poachers by someone in the Spit.

SPARING DOYLE, ROAD-MASTER OF THE SPIT Threat 3 · Flesh 15 · Guard 13 · Attack +5 (ox-goad 3) · Armor 1 · Dread 0. Owns eleven carts and twenty-two oxen, the largest fleet in Wanting; eats on the road and lies about it; is the only person in the Spit with whom the Abstinent will speak directly, and despises them for it.

THE LEAN END

The far western tip of the ridge, beyond the last of the Cold Yards, where the houses thin out into sheds and byres and then stop. The Lean House stands here, long and windowless, and around it a scatter of small, half-empty cottages where the families of the omitted live, close enough to visit and far enough not to have to. Abide Kettering's cart-shed is at the bottom of the lane. So is the Bury Gate, through which the dead of Wanting are carried out to the fields.

It is quiet. It smells of clean straw, lye, and something under it that the Unfed have a word for and other peoples do not: the sweetish, appley, nail-varnish smell of a body in the last week of hunger. It is the only part of Wanting with a view west, and on still evenings the people of the Lean End can see the warm ground beginning a quarter-mile away, and lights in it, here and there, where tables are laid.

Custom: people walking to the Lean House are not greeted, not looked at, and not offered anything, as a courtesy. People coming back are greeted as though from a long journey. *Danger:* the view. The Lean End is the stand from which most of Wanting's walkers go: people, omitted or not, who get up in the night and walk west toward a light. The Hostwatch keep a rope strung across the end of the lane, belled, and a watchman, and most nights the watchman hears a bell.

CEASE ABBOT, LEAN END WATCHMAN Threat 2 · Flesh 12 · Guard 12 · Attack +3 (cudgel 3) · Armor 0 · Dread 0. A one-eyed former Tablebreaker who sits up every night by the bell-rope, and who has stopped a hundred walkers, and lately has begun, on some nights, to look the other way.

BELL WARD

The stand of young families, on the gentle southern slope of the ridge, where the houses are smallest and closest together and the doors are hung with hand-bells. Every household with a child under twelve keeps a bell at the door, and at dusk, and whenever the smell on the wind goes sweet, the mother or eldest stands at the door and rings it and counts the children through. On a sweet-smelling evening the whole of Bell Ward rings at once, a thin, frightened,

tinny peal, and the counting can be heard up and down the lanes in a hundred voices: *one, two, three, in. One, two, in.*

Bell Ward smells of wet wool and the sour milk-and-ammonia of babies in hard-washed linen. It sounds like bells, and children reciting the Five Rules in chorus at the Rule-house at the bottom of the slope, where every child of the stand is taught. It is the stand the god loves best, and everyone knows it.

Custom: when a child goes missing, the family rings the bell at dusk for a year and a day, calling the child's name, and then takes the bell down and gives it to the Rule-house, where it hangs on a long beam among hundreds of others. Nobody rings the beam. *Danger:* Little Fain lives here now, with a foster-family who did not ask for the duty, and the other children of Bell Ward follow Fain about.

RULE-MISTRESS WITHHOLD PENN Threat 2 · Flesh 10 · Guard 10 · Attack none · Armor 0 · Dread 0. Teaches the Five Rules to three hundred children; can recite them so fast they sound like a single word; has found, three mornings this season, a little chair pulled out at the Rule-house door, child-sized, the seat warm.

PINNERS' YARD

A walled court behind the Pantry, entered from Pantry Close by a narrow gate, where the Hostwatch keep their lodgings, their rope-store, their lamp-room, and the stair down to the Great Map in the cellar below the Pantry. Trackers come and go at all hours, muddy to the thigh, with warm-ground reports scrawled on slates, and the Pin-Setters run them down the stair to be pricked onto the linen. The Yard is the only place in Wanting where people talk about Orrum as a thing that does things rather than a thing to be refused, and the Abstinent watch it closely.

It smells of lamp oil, wet rope and the beeswax the Pin-Setters use to stiffen their linen. It sounds like boots, the clack of slates, and arguments, low and fierce, about gaits and directions and why the god paused for an hour at a particular gate.

Custom: a Tracker coming in from the field touches the Yard gate with a bare palm and says, aloud, how far they were from the god at the closest. The number is chalked on the gatepost. It has been getting smaller. *Danger:* the Hostwatch's restricted ledgers, which record the extra chair, are kept here, and two Pin-Setters have been omitted from the list in the last year after copying them.

PIN-SETTER ABATE LOWRIE Threat 1 · Flesh 9 · Guard 11 · Attack none · Armor 0 · Dread 0. A fourteen-year-old girl with perfect hands who sets four hundred pins a week, and who has noticed, though nobody has asked her, that the newest pins on the Rim Road make a circle, and that the circle is closing.

KNIFE ROW AND THE WEST GATE

A single long street of hard-used houses running out to the West Gate, where the Reckoners muster on the first day of Carving and where volunteers come to stand and be looked at. Reckoner families live along it, and Reckoners home between raids, and the widows and widowers of Reckoners who did not come home. The doors on Knife Row are painted black, the only painted doors in Wanting, and each one has notches cut in its lintel: one for each line the household's Knives have ended.

Knife Row smells of the grey, fatless leather Reckoners wear, and of whetstone dust, and, faintly, of Rim weather: wet road, foreign smoke. It sounds like boots and very little talk. Reckoners home from a raid do not speak of it, and the Row has a way of falling silent when they pass that is not quite respect.

Custom: a returning band walks the length of the Row from the West Gate to the Pantry carrying nothing, with their empty hands held out at their sides, palms forward, to show they took nothing from the houses they entered. *Danger:* bedside hunger. Reckoners home from the Rim are sometimes not right, and Knife Row has more walkers, more Breaks and more quiet deaths in the night than any stand but the Lean End.

FORSWEAR TALLOW, RECKONER WIDOW Threat 2 · Flesh 11 · Guard 12 · Attack +4 (knife 2) · Armor 0 · Dread 0. A descendant of Forswear Kell, keeper of the Row's notched lintels and its memory; she mends Reckoner greys for nothing, and asks every returning Knife the same question, *what were the beds like*, and writes down the answers.

HOBB'S CORNER

Where Hillward Row meets the Brindle road, the only shop in Wanting: a low grey house with a counter across its front room, kept by the old declining grocer Nay-Saying Hobb, who sells ration-bread, Unfed greys, frost-markers, wax tins, rope, and Tablebreakers' wedges, and who declines every sale three times, as custom requires. The corner around it is the nearest thing Wanting has to a market: on the fourth day of each week a few households set out on cloths whatever they can bear to part with, and other households decline it, and decline it, and decline it, and on the fourth asking a bargain is struck in silence.

It smells of wool, rope and wax. It sounds like a great many polite refusals. The top shelf of Hobb's shop is full, every morning, of bread that nobody baked.

Custom: the Fourth-Day market has no prices. Everything is valued in measures, and every trade is made in the Decline. *Danger:* Hobb's top shelf. He throws the bread into the wind every morning, but children have been seen following it.



BEYOND THE RIDGE

Out from Wanting, inside the Frostline, the Unfed live in hamlets and steadings of between a dozen and a few hundred people, each a cold grey cluster of houses around a bare patch of ground where, in any other land, there would be a green. They live on what the Measure-Bearers carry out to them, and on what they can trade at the Fourth-Day market, and on nothing else. Beyond the Frostline, in Orrum's country, there are no Unfed settlements at all, only the stations of those whose work takes them there.

BRINDLE CROSS

The crossing point where the Wanting road meets the Rim, already described in the core book: toll-house, stockade, weighing-shed, Marshal Keep Aldane's garrison of sixty, and the Brimming Cup on the Rim side. At ground level it is the noisiest place an Unfed child will ever see: Company wagons, drovers swearing in six accents, oxen bawling, the clatter of scales, the Brimming Cup's kitchen door banging open and shut and letting out gusts of frying. Unfed clerks in grey stand at the weighing-shed with their noses plugged and sign for sacks they do not open.

The garrison's huts stand on the Fast side, behind a ditch, and they are cold, because Aldane will not have a fire in them. The pilgrim camp has grown up along the Rim side of the ditch since 640: tents, lean-tos, carts, and some three hundred Fatlanders sitting in the mud, waiting to be allowed through, and singing.

Custom: the eight-year-olds of Wanting are brought here once to watch Rim folk eat through the Brimming Cup's window. Afterward they are made to say the Decline at the window, three times, while the diners watch them back. *Danger:* everything at the Cross is for sale, including people, and the pilgrims are now so many that the garrison cannot watch the ditch at night.

TALLY-CLERK SPARE ORME, PANTRY WEAHER AT THE CROSS

Threat 2 · Flesh 10 · Guard 10 · Attack none · Armor 0 · Dread 0. Has signed for every sack that has come through Brindle Cross in nine years, and knows to the bushel how much lighter the autumn deliveries were; has written it down twice, and both pages have gone missing from his ledger.

AVERY STEADING

A hamlet of a hundred and forty souls, the furthest north-east of any Unfed settlement, at the end of a stony track two days' walk from Wanting, on a bleak shoulder of upland where the Rim's winter bites hard. Its houses are older than Wanting, built by families who would not move all the way in, and the Avery family has held its stand there for four hundred years. It is a village of old people. Most of its young have gone to Wanting or the Reckoners; there are nine children. It is the furthest from the Pantry, the oldest, and the one with the fewest children, which is to say that it is exactly the kind of village Mother Stint Avery has put on her winter list.

It smells of peat they are not allowed to burn, sheep-wool caught on the thorns, and the cold. It sounds like wind, which is rare in the Fast and precious, and the old people of Avery Steading sit in it with their faces turned up, because wind means the god is far away. They trade nothing. They knit. Avery Steading greys are the warmest in the Fast, and the village sends them down to the Fourth-Day market in bales.

Custom: the steading keeps a "letter to the Keeper", a long cloth onto which every household stitches one line each Lack, telling the Pantry how they are. It is sent down with the Measure-Bearer. Mother Stint Avery, who was born here, reads it every year, and has never answered it. *Danger:* the Measure-Bearer's road is long, and in Lack the snow cuts the steading off for weeks at a time. This winter, when the snow comes, the Bearer will not set out.

GRANDAM BARE AVERY, THE STEADING'S ELDEST

Threat 2 · Flesh 8 · Guard 9 · Attack none · Armor 0 · Dread 0. Ninety-four, Stint Avery's great-aunt, still knitting; has had a dream three nights running in which Stint, as a girl of nine, stands at the steading stone with a basket and walks past.

THINWICK

A hamlet of sixty people two hours' walk south of Wanting, on a chalk stream that the Unfed drink from because it is not offered. It is a poor place even by the Fast's measure: thatched cottages whose thatch nobody can afford to renew, a Rule-stone where the children recite, a single well with a lid chained shut. Abstain Rooke lives here with her mother. So do two families of Reckoners and a retired Tablebreaker who sits by the stream all day mending axe-hafts for the whole district.

Thinwick smells of wet chalk and watercress, which grows in the stream and which nobody may eat, since it grows in the Fast. It sounds like water. The children of Thinwick are the best-behaved in the district, because the hamlet is on the edge of the Frostline, and the warm ground comes up to the bottom of its lane every few weeks and lies there all night like a dog by a door.

Custom: every Thinwick window has a sill, and every sill is kept bare. The hamlet's mothers check them at dawn. One has not been checked in a while, because the mother of that house has been working double turns in the Cold Yards since her name was moved to the bottom of the list. *Danger:* the warm ground, and what is on the sill.

HAFT-MENDER LEAN COYLE, RETIRED AXE

Threat 2 · Flesh 12 · Guard 12 · Attack +5 (axe 4) · Armor 0 · Dread 0. Broke seventy tables in his day; now mends hafts and watches the children; has seen what the Rooke girl puts on her windowsill, and has not decided what to do about it, because the cake that came back last week smelled like his wife's.

CORVE HATCH

The ruined village where, in 44 A.G., the family of Abel Corve sat down at their own table. The village was abandoned within a decade of the First Sitting, and it lies now well beyond the Frostline, in the kept country, a quarter-hour from the Long Table road. Its houses are perfect. The Corve house stands in the middle of them with its window bricked up from outside. The family is still at their table, behind the brick. The Hostwatch, who have put an ear to the wall, say that on still nights you can hear a spoon, very slowly, against a plate, about once an hour.

The Corve family's descendants, by a sister who did not sit, live in Wanting and in Hillward, and they make a pilgrimage here once a year, on the anniversary of the sitting, to stand with their backs to the bricked window through a night. It is the only pilgrimage the Unfed make that is not to Hallowboard, and it is a pilgrimage of shame.

Custom: every visitor adds a brick. The bricking over the window is now four feet thick and has begun to lean. *Danger:* the village is laid for guests. Every house in Corve Hatch has its table set every night, and every door is open a hand's width, and the voices that call from them are Corve voices, saying, *Cousin, cousin, there's plenty, come and sit with us.*

BARROWGATE

A cluster of a dozen hard little stone huts at the foot of Hallowboard hill, beside the Barrows, the only Unfed settlement in the heartland, permitted by the Abstinent because someone must keep the Stand-Roll. The Stand-Roll is a ledger of the trench: an account, stretch by stretch and footprint by footprint, of which family is believed to have stood where on the nine days of the Refusal. Unfed who come to swear an oath on the ones who stood come to Barrowgate first, to be told by the Roll-Keepers where their ancestor's footprint is. The Keepers are a hereditary order of eight families, and they live on a full measure, carried out by Bearers who walk two days each way to bring it.

Barrowgate smells of chalk dust and the long pale grass of the Barrows, which smells, on warm evenings, like hair. It is very quiet. It sounds like the Roll-Keepers reciting the Roll, which takes three days to say aloud and is said once a season. The hill above is always clean.

Custom: a swearer walks up the hill barefoot, and down it backward, never turning their back on the stone until they are out of sight of it, and then turns and walks home without looking round. *Danger:* the eighth side. The Roll-Keepers do not keep a record for it, and do not let anyone stand there, and do not say why, and lately they have taken to sleeping in shifts, because on still nights something has been walking around the stone, slowly, and stopping on that side, and standing there, and the chalk in the morning is still untrodden.

ROLL-KEEPER REFT LAMMAS Threat 2 · Flesh 10 · Guard 11 ·

Attack none · Armor 0 · Dread 0. Seventy, keeper of the third stretch of the Stand-Roll, who can tell from a footprint in the chalk the weight and age of the person who made it six hundred years ago; she has started finding new footprints, small and bare and fresh, in the old ones.

SPLINTERHALL

A long turf-roofed lodge and a scatter of huts in a hollow four miles west of Wanting, just inside the Frostline, where the Tablebreaker bands of the eastern Fast make their base. It is the only place in the Fast where axes are made, and the hollow rings all day with the sound of hafts being shaped and heads being ground. A great heap of splinters stands in the middle of the hollow, a hundred feet across and twenty high, made of the broken pieces of every table the eastern bands have smashed for two hundred years. Nobody burns it. The splinters do not rot. Some days the heap is warm.

Splinterhall smells of fresh-cut ash, oil, and the faint baking smell that rises from the splinter-heap. It sounds like grinding and the slap of axe-heads tested on stumps. The Breakers who live here are proud, deafened, half-blind from years of gauze, and very good company.

Custom: every new Axe brings a splinter from their first table and throws it on the heap without looking. An Old Breaker's splinter is kept, and set into the lodge wall, with their name. *Danger:* the heap. Anyone who sleeps beside it wakes with crumbs on their lips.

OLD BREAKER WANE HOLLISTER Threat 4 · Flesh 15 · Guard

15 · Attack +7 (Barrow-blessed axe 4) · Armor 1 · Dread 0. Ran Splinterhall for twenty years and has broken three hundred tables; she has taken to sleeping on the heap, and the bands have noticed that she is gaining weight.

WAX HALT

A stone post-house at the eastern mouth of the Long Table valley, where the old straight road across the heartland enters between the beech hills. It is not a village, only a waystation kept by a single family on a Pantry charter, and its purpose is to wax the ears of travellers before they take the Long Table road. The family sells wax and tallow plugs, linen nose-binds, blinders, and rope, and keeps a register of everyone who goes in and everyone who comes out the far end at the West Mouth, nine miles on. The two lists are compared by runner every week. They do not always match.

Wax Halt smells of melted tallow and the faint baking smell that rolls out of the valley mouth on the still air. It sounds, if you take your plugs out, like a distant murmur of eleven thousand people talking happily over dinner.

Custom: travellers going in leave something of theirs on the Halt's long shelf (a glove, a knife, a button) and take it back on the way out. The shelf is full of things nobody came back for. *Danger:* the Halt-keepers. The family has kept Wax Halt for six generations and in that time has never once taken out its own ear-plugs, and it shows.

HALT-KEEPER SOBER PELL Threat 2 · Flesh 11 · Guard 11 · Attack +3 (cudgel 3) · Armor 0 · Dread 1. Has worn wax in his ears since he was six; speaks too loudly; reads lips; has begun to suspect that his wife has been taking her plugs out at night to listen, and that she is smiling.

SAINTS' ACRE

A sweep of open fields south of Wanting, outside the last hamlet but inside the Frostline, where the Starved Saints sit. The order has no house. Its Abstainers sit in the open on hurdles and in shallow scrapes, wrapped in sacking, spaced well apart so that no one is near enough to offer anyone anything, and the Watchers walk among them, tending the dying and recording last refusals. The field is dotted with low stones. Each marks where an Abstainer sat and stopped.

It smells of cold earth and, faintly, of the pear-drop sweetness of fasting breath, so strong in places that it catches in the throat. It

sounds like the Decline, said at every sound, so that a crow landing or a pilgrim's footstep sets off a soft wave of *no, thank you* across the whole field. Pilgrims from Wanting, and lately from the Rim, come to the field's edge to touch the robes of the Saints who have lasted, and are kept back by the Watchers.

Custom: families of novices come to the field's edge to plead, and stand at a distance, because to offer food would be an insult. They are allowed to stand as long as they like. Some stand until the end. *Danger:* the field is changing. Sister Nay Corliss has sat here three years. The frost around her hurdle melts each night in a wide ring, and two other Abstainers have moved their hurdles closer to her.

WATCHER SCARCITY DUNNE Threat 2 · Flesh 9 · Guard 10 · Attack none · Armor 0 · Dread 0. A tall, hollow-eyed woman of forty who keeps the Book of Last Refusals; she has written two thousand names in it, and has noticed that in the last year, for the first time, the field's dead are not losing weight.



PART TWO

LEAVINGS

What is left of a god when someone takes a knife to it.

CHAPTER 2

THE CARVING KNIFE

The Taking of Leavings

We ate them once because we had to. We go on eating them because we have learned what the pieces do.

— MOTHER GALL, PICKLER, TO A CUSTOMER

TESTIMONY OF A GLEANER TAKEN BY THE MORTUARY COURT, LASTGATE, 640 A.G. THE CLERK NOTES THAT THE WITNESS SMELLED OF VINEGAR AND WOULD NOT SIT DOWN.

You want to know how it is done. It is done like butchery, because it is butchery. You need a cold room or a cold night, a good blade, a bucket, salt, and a friend who can hold a lamp without looking. You need to know what you are cutting for: a finger is not a finger, sir, a Hand-line finger is a key, a Hand-line finger is a death, and if you cut it at the wrong joint you have a grey dead stick and nothing more. You need to know how long you have. Some things go off in a breath. Some things never go off, and those are worse.

And you need to know what it costs you. I have carved forty-one leavings in my life. I have sold all but one. The one I kept

is in my mouth, under my tongue. I cannot take it out. That is not a figure of speech.

No, I will not show you. Ask the next question.

A god is a body. When six peoples ate their Providers on the Night of Seven Tables, they did not eat all of it: there were bones that would not crack, organs that would not cook, blood that would not clot, parts that were hidden, stolen, buried or kept. And the gods have been growing back ever since, in their eaters' bloodlines, soil, weather and dead, which means that every land on the Table is full of god again: in the hands of its nobles, the mouths of its Laden, the lungs of its Tenanted, the eyes of its sleepers, the cords of its Uncut, the tongues of its Sayers, and the crumbs on the Host's tables.

The people of the Table call the things that can be taken from all this **leavings**: what is left on the plate. This chapter explains how leavings are known, carved, kept and used. The catalogues that follow describe them land by land.

EVERYTHING ON THE TABLE IS FOOD, OR WAS. EVERYTHING ON THE TABLE IS A GOD, OR WILL BE.

[CUTWRIGHTS' COLLEGE, FIRST LECTURE]

▼ THE ANATOMY OF A LEAVING

Every leaving in the catalogues is described with six entries.

- ◇ **WHISPERED**: how hard it is to have heard of the leaving: what it is, where it comes from, what it does. A character rolls **Eye + Lore** (or another pair the Carver allows: **Eye + Reckoning** for a Seamer's anatomy, **Caul + Rites** for a priest's legend, **Tongue + Haggle** for a fence's gossip) against the listed difficulty. Success means they know of it; a **Helping** reveals its **Taint**; a **Grace** reveals one false belief that people hold about it. Failure means they know only rumours, which the Carver may make false.
- ◇ **SPOILAGE**: how long the leaving stays potent once taken from its source, and what keeps it. A spoiled leaving is only meat,

bone or water, though often it is still **Tainted**.

- ◇ **CARVING**: how the leaving is taken: from what, or whom, with which tools, by which roll, at what risk. Carving is described below.
- ◇ **TAINT**: the residue of the god the leaving carries, using the **Taint** rules of the Rim Market chapter (**Hunger**, **Regrowth** or **Dread**, rated 1–5).
- ◇ **EFFECT**: what the leaving does, in the rules.
- ◇ **WORTH**: its price in lacks (if it is sold at all), its availability rating, where it changes hands and whether it is legal.

▼ KNOWING

Leavings are surrounded by more lies than any other trade on the Table. Every second stall on the Rim Road sells a “Hand-line knuckle” that is a pig’s; every inn has a man who knows a man who has a bottle of Hush. The WHISPERED roll protects the Guests from the obvious frauds, but the Carver should be generous with rumours and stingy with certainty. A leaving’s true effect is often

learned only by using it, and some of the catalogue’s effects are meant to be discovered that way, at the worst moment.

Identifying a specific item in hand (is this the real thing?) uses the Rim Market rules: **Eye + Lore**, Hard (14) to identify a Taint’s kind and rating, Grim (18) to identify which god. Cutwrights, Seamers, Renderers and Midwives may substitute their Calling’s signature skill when the leaving falls within their trade.

▼ CARVING

Carving a leaving is a **Long Task** with a single climactic roll. The catalogue entry gives:

- ◇ **The source.** A living person, a corpse, a horror, a place, a table, an object.
- ◇ **The tools.** A carving kit (Seamer’s or Renderer’s) is assumed. Some leavings need special tools: lead jars, brine-casks, gold wire, a Waker’s needle, a lit candle, silence. Without them the Difficulty rises by one step or the carving is impossible.
- ◇ **The roll.** Usually **Hand + Stitching** (surgery and fine cutting) or **Hand + Blades** (butchery), against the listed Difficulty. Other pairs appear where they fit: Caul + Rites to take something holy without waking it, Eye + Reckoning to bottle a place, Tongue + Clause to take a word.
- ◇ **The Dread.** Almost every carving calls for a Dread check before the roll: the Carver should describe, fully, what the carver is doing with their hands. Failing the Dread check imposes –2 on the carving roll.
- ◇ **Helpings.** Each Helping on a carving roll either doubles the yield (two doses, a larger piece) or extends the Spoilage by one step (minutes to hours, hours to days, days to a season).
- ◇ **Grace.** A perfect cut: the leaving is taken whole, with maximum yield and no backlash, and the carver gains a Portion for their mastery.
- ◇ **Lack.** The carving goes wrong in the way the entry describes. If no backlash is listed, the leaving is ruined and the carver suffers the item’s Taint as though they had used it.

CARVING FROM THE LIVING

Many of the most potent leavings must be taken from people who are still alive: a Kept limb, a Gut-line’s marbled fat, a Lung-line’s breath, an Eye-line’s lash, a Caul-line’s veil, a Tongue-line’s word. A willing donor makes a carving one step easier, and the Table has a

long and terrible tradition of willing donors: debtors, the desperate, the devout, mothers selling for their children. An unwilling donor must be held or drugged, and the act is a **Dread 3** horror for the carver (Dread 4 if the donor is someone they know; kin-carving is Dread 4 and counts as the act a character would not do, if that is their line). Carving from the living deals damage to the donor as listed, often a Mangling result chosen rather than rolled.

Carving the living is murder or mutilation under the law of every land, save where it is licensed: Sallowreach licenses part-sales by the Kept themselves, the Fatlands licenses the render of the dead, and the Attendance of Cradlewrack claims all Parts. Everywhere else, it is a hanging.

CARVING THE DEAD AND THE DESECRATED

Carving a corpse is grave desecration in every land but the Fatlands. It is easier (one step) and usually less potent. In Sallowreach, of course, the dead feel everything, and will remember who did it.

Grave-oaths sworn over a body that has been carved bind twice as hard (see Oaths on the Dead in the core book). Many carvers swear such an oath before they begin, to make the leaving stronger: *On your name, I will use what I take from you well*. Some leavings in the catalogues require it.

CARVING PLACES

Some leavings are taken not from bodies but from places where a god is close: a jar of Hush, a skin of the Trench’s water, a breath of the long room, a handful of crowning-clay, a stone from Sworn Gorge, a crumb from a laid table. Carving a place usually means **Eye + Reckoning** (measuring, sealing, timing) or **Caul + Godsign** (sensing where the god is thin), and always means being in the place long enough to suffer it: each attempt costs the carver the place’s Hunger, Fray or Dread as described in the land chapters.

▼KEEPING: SPOILAGE AND PRESERVATION

Leavings spoil. The god wants to go home, and a leaving taken away from its source begins at once to lose its grip. Spoilage is listed in steps:

SPOILAGE	LASTS	COMMON PRESERVATION
Breath	a few heartbeats; must be used on the spot	none possible
Minutes	about ten minutes	salt and darkness extend to an hour
Hours	a day at most	brine, lead, cold extend to a week
Days	about a week	wax, pickling, Mother Gall's brine extend to a season
Seasons	a season	sealed lead and Hush-wax extend to a year
Never	it does not spoil	nothing makes it less potent

Each land has its own preservation craft. Sallowreach preserves in vinegar, lacquer and the weighted dark of the Sump; nothing spoils there, which is why its leavings fetch more abroad. The Fatlands salt, smoke and render. Brinehollow keeps things wet, in brine taken from its own people's lungs. The Vigil keeps things lit and watched, because what is not watched in the Vigil goes to sleep. Cradlewrack keeps things shut, and nothing in Cradlewrack stays shut. Oathen

keeps things by promising to keep them, which works exactly as long as the promise does. The Fast keeps nothing; its leavings neither spoil nor stay.

A leaving that is carried on a **living body**, sewn under the skin, held in the mouth, worn on a cord against the breastbone, keeps one step longer. It also counts as worn against the skin for Taint every day.

USING LEAVINGS

Unless an entry says otherwise:

- ◇ Using a leaving takes an action in combat or a few moments otherwise.
- ◇ Its **Taint** applies on use, as the Rim Market chapter describes.
- ◇ A character may have the effects of **no more leavings at once than their Caul rating**. More than that, and the gods begin to argue inside them: the Carver rolls a d10 for each excess leaving every scene, and on a 1 that leaving's Taint applies again.
- ◇ Leavings from a **foreign god** use the Rim Market's foreign-god rules. Characters who carry leavings of three or more gods gain the Derangement *The Voice at Table*, speaking in several voices.
- ◇ **Blanks and the Unfed** use leavings normally, except that Hunger Taint does not touch them and Regrowth Taint Seasons them (see the Rim Market). Leavings are the most common way an Unfed comes to carry a god.

▼ TRADING LEAVINGS

Leavings are the most valuable trade on the Table and the most dangerous. Every land has laws against some of them and a black market in all of them. The Rim Road Company officially trades

none and unofficially taxes them all at the toll-gates, as “Breath” (a lack a post for any traveller carrying godsign at the Course, a rule the Company's Wardens interpret broadly).

WHERE	WHAT SELLS	WHO BUYS
Lastgate, the Sinks	Kept parts, Hand-line relics, Hush-wax	Vigil envoys, Fatlands dying, Second Table
Sated, the Chute	Gut-line cuts, Laden-soil, toothed grain	everyone; it is the breadbasket
Lowmark, the far pier	brine, Tenanted shells, Uncovered salvage	Vigil rouse-cutters, apothecaries
The Slope, the Vigil	lashes, sleeper-breath, Seeming-ink	anyone who must not sleep or must
Kest, the back of the Lying-In	Parts, cauls, cord, crowning-clay	Assemblers, Brinehollow buyers, surgeons
Tacit, the Breakdowns	Sayer-wax, Forsworn bone, echo-stones	Clausewrights, foreign courts, the desperate
Wanting, after dark	crumbs, cards, steward's linen	pilgrims, Second Table, the starving
Every Rim waystation	fakes	everyone

THE PRICE OF A GOD

Leavings in the catalogues have prices, but price is the least of their cost. A Carver running a campaign rich in leavings should keep a simple tally for each Guest of *every leaving they have used*, and let it show. People who wear the gods on cords around their necks start to smell like the lands those gods were eaten in. Cutwrights can read it on them. The Reckoners can, too.

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